

I Love You Too

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Whenever my sister sees a baby, she calls my name. I used to get embarrassed and correct her immediately, hoping to ease the confusion of the baby’s parents.

There is a picture I love to look at. In it, my sister is five and I am three. I look confused, as many toddlers do, but my sister is holding my hand and looking straight into the camera. Her eyes are bright and serious, and her small hand holds mine firmly, as if she already feels responsible for me as an older sister. The picture feels bittersweet because I no longer remember what it felt like to rely on her that way.

As I grew up, my role changed. I was first her younger sister, then her playmate and friend, and now I often find myself taking on the role of an older sister. I help her through unfamiliar situations, speak up when others do not understand her, and try to protect her from a world that is not always patient. Yet even as my role has changed, she has continued carrying a younger version of me in her heart.

That realization makes me feel both loved and guilty. I was not always a good younger sister to her. At times, words came out of my mouth that were not as respectful or kind as she deserved. I felt frustrated when I could not understand what she wanted to tell me, or when she could not understand me. Reading her face was difficult, especially because her expressions were often subtle and nonverbal.

It used to hurt when I told her “I love you” and did not hear those words back. I thought love had to return in the same language I had offered it. Over time, I slowly learned that my sister had been answering me all along. She rarely says affection aloud, but whenever she draws in her sketchbook, she almost always draws our family, giving each of us distinct features and personalities. She still calls me by the childhood nickname I sometimes wonder if I still deserve. She still wants to act out the pretend stories we used to play with our dolls, and she remembers the smallest details from our family road trips, even teasing me by repeating things I said. Her love may not always come as a sentence, but it is careful, repeated, and unmistakable.

Being her sister has taught me that communication is not only about speaking clearly. It is about trying again after misunderstanding. It is about learning another person’s rhythm, even when it is different from your own. My sister and I do not always begin in the same language, but we often arrive at the same conclusion: we are listening, we are trying, and we love each other.

Now, when she sees a small child and calls my name, I no longer try to correct her. I think of that old picture, of her small hand holding mine. Then I hold her hand, the way she once held mine, and tell her what I have finally learned to understand: “I love you too.”